



SOUTH AFRICANS TOUCH A MODEL OF THE FIFA WORLD CUP TROPHY AS THEY CHEER FOR THE NATIONAL TEAM BAFANA BAFANA

specialists of Europe.

One of the early controversies was the stampede that occurred in a friendly game involving Nigeria and North Korea. Only 10,000 tickets had been allocated at the small venue, probably because organisers had not reckoned with the burgeoning Nigerian community in this country.

It was akin to hosting an Indian national cricket team match in Birmingham or Manchester with free entrance, and then being surprised when 50,000 fanatics turned up.

It is also only in Africa, as one British journalist observed, that you will find security guards striking in the middle of the most important sporting event of our lives. The strike by the security guards against unpaid wages took place in Durban, Cape Town and Johannesburg. As a bystander, you have to dubiously hand it to the guards for picking an opportune time to riot. If ever their demands will be met, it is now.

Another serious bone of contention has been the dreaded Vuvuzela. Players and broadcasters from abroad have whined consistently about its impact, but funnily enough, the visiting fans seem to have adopted it as a sig-

nificant part of the whole experience. I went to the Germany vs Australia game at the magnificent Moses Mabhida Stadium in Durban, and there were just as many Vuvuzelas amongst the German throngs as there were within the local lot.

My view is that when in Rome, one should certainly be like the locals. Sepp Blatter himself has come to the poor Vuvuzela's rescue, saying they are a part of our footballing culture. That is certainly right, and perhaps the players should rather worry about locating the net with the new Jabulani ball than fret about what noise is emanating from the stands. Happily, that is not an African model, it is German designers who will field a volley of accusations.

The first World Cup in Africa was always going to be different, and it has had its fair share of surprises. Locals in Durban have been pleasantly surprised by the thousands of Australians who converged onto Kingsmead Stadium, and pitched tents for the next few weeks. For this one time only, it is actually a pleasure to see an Australian

looking so comfortable within one of our premier Test cricket venues.

This football frenzy is all new to us, as is the orange army of the Netherlands, the French cockerels in the stands and the numerous foreigners who have just landed in the country on a wing and a prayer. More than a few tourists arrived here expecting an Indian summer, and are now confronted by the near freezing temperatures of a Johannesburg night. It seems most of the travel brochures forgot to mention that June and July is winter in our parts and only Durban provides 'shorts and T-shirt' weather all year.

World Cup fever is certainly here, and as long as Bafana are in the tournament, the nation will be captivated by it all. The other African teams have been a mixed bag, but the Ivory Coast and Ghana look likely to hold the African candle into the latter stages. As I write this, I have just received confirmation for access to the Brazil vs Portugal game. Strangely enough, there is nowhere else I would rather be.

The author is sports writer for the The Witness, Pietermaritzburg, the oldest daily newspaper in South Africa